



Trump to ax aid for European security

NATO allies alarmed as initiative to deter Russia on eastern flank in peril

BY NOAH ROBERTSON

The Trump administration intends to halt longtime security assistance programs for Europe, including an initiative to fortify the continent's eastern flank against a potential attack by Russia, as it endeavors to recast Washington's role within NATO, according to six people familiar with the matter.

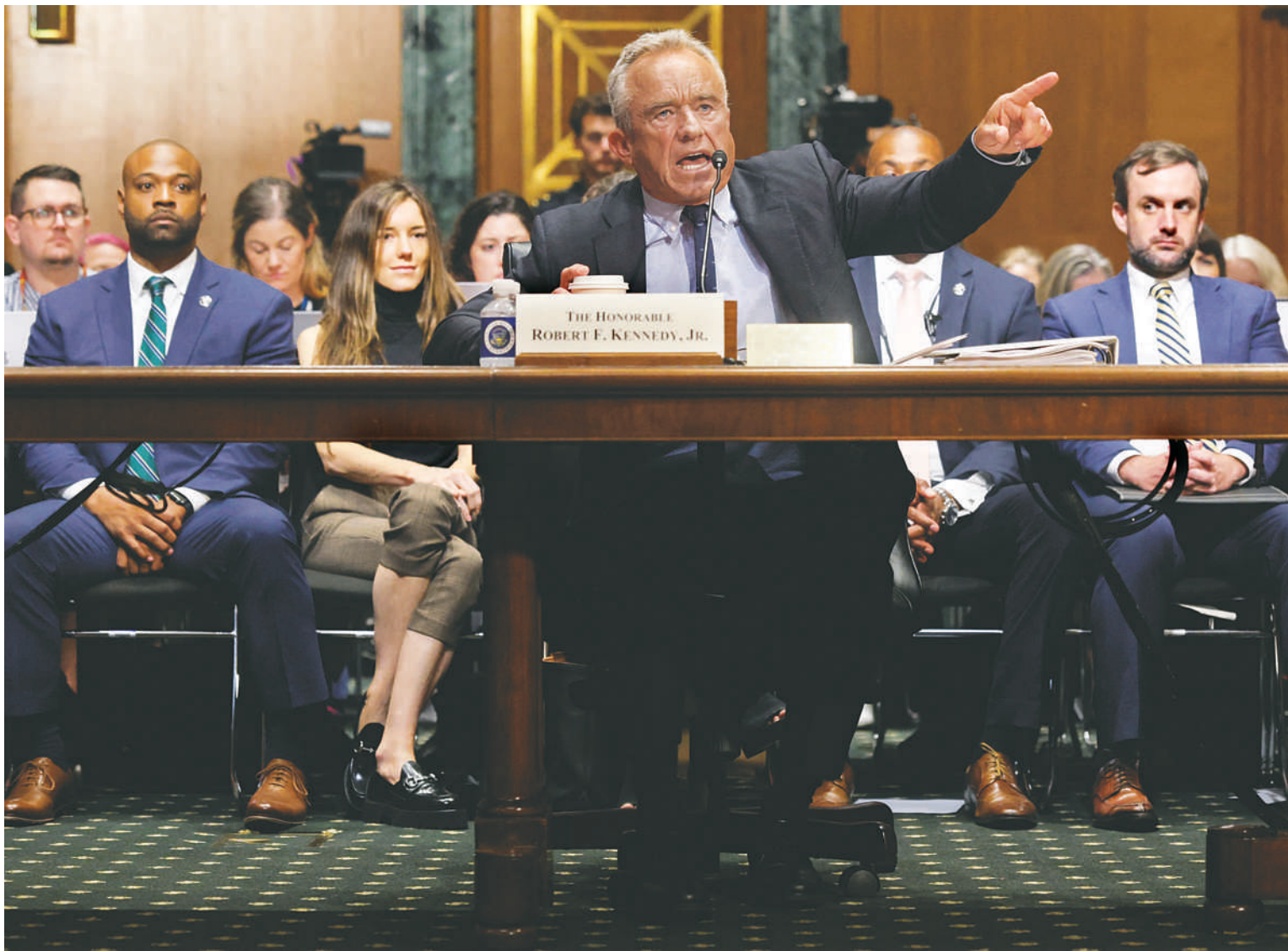
The decision would impact hundreds of millions of dollars worth of military aid relied upon by some of the alliance's most vulnerable members. It has alarmed U.S. allies struggling to comprehend the administration's policy toward Europe and its chief adversary in the Kremlin after President Donald Trump, eager for a deal to end Russia's war in Ukraine, rescued its mercurial leader, Vladimir Putin, from diplomatic isolation. U.S. lawmakers, meanwhile, are confused by the move.

"The Russians genuinely only care about American dollars, American troops and the American flag," said a European official worried what signal a cut in U.S. aid would send to Moscow. Like others, this person spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss a sensitive matter.

In a statement, the White House said its move to slash security assistance was "coordinated" with the Europeans and is consistent both with Trump's executive

SEE EUROPE ON A12

Ukraine: Europeans agree to send troops for postwar security. **A12**



JONATHAN ERNST/REUTERS

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. testifies Thursday before a Senate Finance Committee hearing on health.

RFK Jr. defends moves at Hill hearing

Heated exchanges with lawmakers amid rising frustration over CDC upheaval and vaccine confusion

BY DAVID OVALLE, RACHEL ROUBEIN, LAUREN WEBER AND LENA H. SUN

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. on Thursday defended his handling of vaccines and the ouster of the director of Centers for Disease Control and Prevention during a roughly three-hour Senate hearing.

The hearing provided the first opportunity for lawmakers to grill Kennedy, who has emerged as one

of the most polarizing officials in the Trump administration, after growing frustrations over turmoil at the CDC and confusion over the rollout of updated coronavirus vaccines.

In his opening statement before the Senate Finance Committee, Kennedy touted "the busiest, most proactive administration in HHS history." He cited the agency's moves on pushing companies to eliminate artificial food dyes, addressing drug prices and fighting fraud in health care, among other moves.

Calls for President Donald Trump to fire Kennedy grew among Democratic lawmakers and medical organizations Thursday. Even some Republicans, including the second-highest ranking GOP senator, expressed frustration at Kennedy for challenging long-standing vaccine policies.

White House officials praised Kennedy's performance. On X, Vice President JD Vance ripped Democrats for "lecturing" the secretary, while White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said the administration is "addressing

root causes of chronic disease, embracing transparency in government, and championing gold-standard science. Only the Democrats could attack that common-sense effort."

Kennedy's testimony unfolded more than a week after the White House fired CDC Director Susan Monarez, prompting three senior officials to resign in protest and rolling the agency tasked with

SEE KENNEDY ON A7

Red-blue split: More states break from federal vaccine guidelines. **A6**

Cook is facing fraud probe

CASE CENTERS ON LOAN APPLICATIONS

DOJ's involvement raises stakes for Fed governor

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK AND ANDREW ACKERMAN

The Justice Department has opened a criminal mortgage fraud investigation of Federal Reserve Board member Lisa Cook, a sharp escalation of the Trump administration's efforts to oust her from the central bank's board, according to two people familiar with the matter.

Investigators in recent days have issued subpoenas as part of the inquiry, which originated with a criminal referral from Bill Pulte, director of the Federal Housing Finance Agency, according to the two people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the ongoing investigation.

Pulte has accused Cook of making false statements on mortgage applications in connection with a home in Michigan and a condominium in Georgia. The probe is being overseen by Ed Martin, the director of the department's Weaponization Working Group, who is also overseeing similar mortgage fraud investigations involving Trump foes referred for investigation by Pulte such as Sen. Adam Schiff (D-California) and New York Attorney General

SEE COOK ON A16

Fed pick: Nominee will not resign White House role if confirmed. **A16**

GIORGIO ARMANI 1934-2025

Signature fashions transformed red carpet

BY MEGAN McDONOUGH

Five years after the launch of his luxury fashion house, Giorgio Armani secured his place in fashion history when he created the scene-stealing wardrobe for actor Richard Gere in "American Gigolo."

The 1980 film — with Gere as a bare-chested ladies' man pawing his collection of Armani suits, shirts and ties — forged a vivid link between clothes and seduction, and forever made the designer's relaxed style of tailored dressing part of the fashion vernacular.

His signature wide-shouldered, double-breasted, broad-lapeled blazers came to embody success, sophistication and self-assurance — and became the uniform of the power crowd from Hollywood to Wall Street to Fleet Street in London. His made-to-

SEE ARMANI ON A14

Appreciation: He built the world of quiet luxury one suit at a time. **B1**

A new target of organized crime: Racing pigeons

The birds became a prize for the Chinese elite, and some people were willing to steal them

BY KEVIN SIEFF IN LIMBURG, BELGIUM

The Chinese businessmen arrived in the Belgian countryside driving luxury sports cars, ferrying translators and bags of cash. When they parked in front of Tom Van Gaver's small brick farmhouse, he knew why they had crossed the world to see him.

They wanted his pigeons. Van Gaver, 38, had been breeding racing pigeons since he was 5. It was a hobby he inherited from his father who inherited it from his great grandfather. The pigeons could find their way home from hundreds of miles away, flying at 50 miles per hour. Van Gaver's birds, which he entered in national races, were among the best in Belgium.

For a century, pigeon racers — they call themselves fanciers — were mostly Flemish farmers who invested more in the sport than they made from it. Van Gaver, blond hair swept across his forehead and stray feathers on his hoodie, was a secretary at the local police department. He had time on his hands after a soccer injury and a breakup (he named one of his best pigeons after his ex-girlfriend). The sport was a way to fill his weekends. The idea that it could be lucrative seemed absurd.

Then the Chinese discovered



CHLOE SHARROCK/MYOP/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Pigeons in Tom Van Gaver's Belgium loft, where he breeds some of the country's best racing birds.

pigeon racing.

They learned that the most refined pigeon lineages were in the Belgian countryside. And some of the very best were in Van Gaver's backyard. Beginning in around 2019,

wealthy Chinese industrialists started spending millions on Belgian pigeons. That year, a pigeon named Armando sold for \$1.4 million at an auction outside Brussels. In 2020, another bird named New Kim sold

for \$1.9 million. Pigeon races in major Chinese cities became opulent symbols of China's economic boom, with purses over \$100 million — exceeding most of the world's major sports.

SEE PIGEONS ON A10

District AG sues Trump over Guard deployment

The second lawsuit from Brian Schwalb seeks to halt troops' mobilization

BY MEAGAN FLYNN

D.C. Attorney General Brian Schwalb on Thursday sued President Donald Trump and his administration over the deployment of the National Guard in the nation's capital, describing it as an illegal "military occupation" that has turned domestic troops into local police.

The lawsuit is the second one that Schwalb has filed against Trump since the president declared a "crime emergency" in D.C. on Aug. 11 and asserted control over city police while deploying military troops onto city streets. Schwalb is seeking to force the administration to withdraw the National Guard from the city and enjoin it from pursuing similar actions in the nation's capital.

Unlike state governors, the D.C. mayor does not have control over

SEE TROOPS ON A4

'Constitutional crisis': Judge assails policing surge in D.C. **B13**

IN THE NEWS

Strange reassignments To fill vacancies after earlier firings and resignations, federal agencies are moving workers into roles they know nothing about. **A5**

Jewish Museum killings A Chicago man pleaded not guilty in the shooting of two Israeli Embassy employees. **B13**

THE NATION The Pentagon has approved a plan to use a Chicago Navy base for ICE operations. **A3**
The White House asked the high court for a speedy intervention to allow Trump's tariffs. **A6**

THE WORLD Portugal observed a day of mourning after 16 were killed in a funicular cable car derailment. **A8**
As the U.S. tries to mend ties with India, a trade adviser's rhetoric mixed the message. **A9**

THE ECONOMY Tesla's new model faces a hostile European market as a result of CEO Elon Musk's political antics and rising competition. **A13**
The president's war on wind is getting bigger as the administration seeks to halt a third offshore project in two weeks. **A13**

STYLE The Smithsonian head said an internal team will be formed to review exhibitions after White House pressure. **B1**

SPORTS Maryland, which hosts Northern Illinois tonight, is rocking a revamped defense led by a coach with NFL cred. **B7**

METRO Five Virginia school districts are back in the spotlight over their months-long fight with the federal government over trans policies. **B13**

WEEKEND At Tysons, a culinary crossroads of Afghan staples, Chinese fire starters and Tex-Mex.

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